Through most of the 18th century there was little change in the accepted technology, organization, and tactics of European warfare. When Britain went to war with its North American colonies in 1775, the British "Redcoats" were a well drilled, strictly disciplined force of professional soldiers trained to fight in the open field with musket and bayonet. The American Continental Army employed a similar European style of fighting, and while the guerrilla tactics of American riflemen sometimes revealed the limitations of formal European fighting methods, the essentials of warfare remained the same.



MASS ARMIES

Radical changes that were to reshape the way wars were fought came with the French Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars, between 1792 and 1815. In 1793 the French Republic, established following the overthrow of the king Louis XVI, declared a *levée en masse* or a mass conscription. The decree passed by the National Convention stated: "The young men shall fight; the married men shall forge arms and transport provisions … the old men shall betake themselves to the public squares in order to arouse the courage of the warriors …"

Although the army of the French Republic fell far short of this idealized vision, it did enforce the concept of the ordinary citizen owing a duty of military service as part of "the nation in arms". Linked to the beginnings of industrial-scale production of military equipment, there was a sharp growth in the size of European armies – more than half a million troops were engaged at the battle of Leipzig in 1813. It was Prussia that, in the wake of the Napoleonic Wars, first introduced a system of short-term peacetime conscription, without exemption either on grounds of social class or for payment, so that the mass of the male population would be trained and ready for call-up if a war should break out. Following the widespread adoption of this model, by the early 20th century, the major European powers, Germany, Austria-Hungary, Russia, France, and Italy were in a position to deploy armies numbering millions at very short notice.

STRATEGY AND TACTICS

Napoleon was the commander who, more than any other, established a new approach to warfare to suit the new age. He sought to bring his opponents to battle through the speed of manoeuvre of his mass armies and then crush them by the maximum use of force. On the battlefield, skirmishers were used to harass the enemy before the power of massed artillery,

British Redcoats
In their campaigns against Napoleon, the British infantry under Wellington usually fought defensively in a line, fighting off the enemy with volleys of musket fire. In the Peninsular War (1808–14) and at the Battle of Waterloo in 1815 their discipline won the day against the more aggressive tactics of the French.





